

Connection Workbook

Module map, solo pages, and the Visioning, Intimacy, Legacy and Challenge sections · Module 6 · Family Connection and Communication

Why connection matters for conception

Warm connection releases oxytocin, the counterweight to the stress response (Uvnäs-Moberg, *Frontiers in Psychology*); supportive couple behaviour raised oxytocin and sped wound healing (Gouin et al., *Psychoneuroendocrinology*); strong social relationships were associated with 50% greater likelihood of survival across 148 studies (Holt-Lunstad et al., *PLOS Medicine*); stress markers were linked to lower monthly fecundability (Lynch et al., *Human Reproduction*).

Module 6 at a glance

TRAINING	RUNTIME	RESOURCE	ACTIONS (XP)	TOTAL
T1 · Active Listening Skills	10	Listening Exercises.pdf	Practice 1 session 40 · Reflect 30 · Share 20	90
T2 · Conflict Resolution for Couples	11	Conflict Guide.pdf	Resolve 1 issue 50 · Journal 30 · Share anon. 20	100
T3 · Shared Visioning for Conception	9	this workbook, Visioning	Write vision 40 · Share 30	70
T4 · Intimacy Building Exercises	12	this workbook, Intimacy	Try 1 exercise 40 · Log feelings 30 · Share 20	90
T5 · Family Legacy Planning	10	this workbook, Legacy	Outline legacy 40 · Discuss 30	70
T6 · Connection Challenge	11	this workbook, Challenge	Complete 50 · Reflect 30 · Share 20	100
Module completion bonus				10

Doing this solo? Every section has a solo version. Your circle (a parent, sibling, friend, accountability partner, the forum) is the same medicine.

Visioning (Training 3)

Partners who pursue goals as a unit do better (transactive goal dynamics: Fitzsimons, Finkel & vanDellen, *Psychological Review*); feeling connected to your future self improves present decisions (Hershfield). Do this somewhere that isn't where the hard conversations happen.

Step 1 · Values sort (separately, then compare)

Circle your top five: adventure · security · faith · health · humour · learning · tradition · generosity · calm · creativity · honesty · family closeness · independence · nature · community · beauty · discipline · play · service · curiosity · loyalty · courage · simplicity · hospitality · justice · rest · ambition · kindness · resilience · gratitude

Partner 1's five: _____ Partner 2's five: _____

Shared: _____ Different (and that's information, not a problem): _____

Step 2 · A day in the life, five years from now (present tense, an ordinary Saturday)

Partner 1:

Partner 2:

Read them to each other using the listening loop. Keep both; let the letter hold the overlap.

Date: _____

Share (30 XP): read the letter aloud to each other once; post one line, the one that made you most emotional to write, in the forum.

Intimacy (Training 4)

Non-sexual touch raised oxytocin and lowered blood pressure (Light, Grewen & Amico, *Biological Psychology*); a four-week warm-touch routine raised oxytocin and lowered a stress marker (Holt-Lunstad et al., *Psychosomatic Medicine*); two minutes of mutual gaze increased affection (Kellerman et al., *Journal of Research in Personality*); scheduled, outcome-focused intercourse is linked to lower satisfaction and more distress in both partners (*Journal of Sexual Medicine*). The strategy: rebuild closeness outside the bedroom so the bedroom gets its meaning back.

Boundaries page (fill in together first)

What I'm comfortable with this week: _____ / _____

What I'd rather not do yet: _____ / _____

Our agreed word if either of us wants to stop: _____ Nights that stay non-sexual by agreement: _____

The five exercises (try one this week: 40 XP)

#	EXERCISE	HOW	KIND OF INTIMACY
1	Six-second hug	once a day at an agreed moment (homecoming); long enough to feel your breathing settle	physical
2	Warm touch	10 min, 3× this week: neck/shoulder rub, hand-holding, a hand on the back while they breathe; swap; no talking required; never turns into anything else on agreed nights	physical
3	Eye gazing	face each other, knees nearly touching, 2-minute timer, just look; expect laughter, then softening; each say one thing you noticed	emotional
4	Walk-and-talk, upgraded	20 min, hands held for part; prompt: "What made you fall in love with me, and is it still true?"	intellectual + experiential
5	Sensate reset (Masters & Johnson)	one week with intercourse off the table by agreement; unhurried, non-genital touch, taking turns, noticing what feels good; no goal	for couples where the bedroom has become the hard part

Feelings log (30 XP)

DAY	EXERCISE	BEFORE (1 WORD)	AFTER (1 WORD)	STRESS 1–10 AFTER	NOTES

Share (20 XP): which exercise and one word. No detail needed.

When to reach out: if intimacy has become painful, physically or emotionally, or desire has gone and stayed gone, a couples counsellor or certified sex therapist works with exactly this; clinics can refer. Early is better.

Legacy (Training 5)

Epigenetic inheritance through eggs and sperm is real in mammals, mechanisms still being mapped (Daxinger & Whitelaw, *Nature Reviews Genetics*); the preconception window shapes the child's lifetime health (Fleming et al., *The Lancet*, 2018). Not every habit leaves an inherited mark; the direction is what matters. The visible legacy, what a child copies, is not in doubt.

Three questions about our two families of origin

What do we keep (three each: a tradition, a value, a food, a way of speaking):

Partner 1: _____ Partner 2: _____

What do we change (one pattern each we won't pass on; naming is choosing, not blaming):

Partner 1: _____ Partner 2: _____

What do we start (three new traditions small enough to keep):

TRADITION	WHEN	WHO	HOW IT LOOKS WITH A CHILD AT THE TABLE
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Values map: the five words our home will be known for

_____ · _____ · _____ · _____ · _____ Where we'll put the card: _____

Twelve discussion starters (take a walk and use three)

1. What's one thing your mum or dad did that you want to do exactly the same way?
2. What did your family never talk about that we're going to talk about?
3. What was dinner like in your house, and what do we want it to be like in ours?
4. How was rest treated? How was stress? How were bodies talked about?
5. What's a tradition we've already started without noticing?
6. If our child described our home in three words at age ten, what would we want them to be?
7. What did your grandparents give you that you want to pass on?
8. What's one belief about food, money or work you'd like to rewrite?
9. How did your family celebrate? How did they grieve?
10. What will we teach about sugar, screens and sleep, and how will we model it?
11. Who else will be part of this child's life, and what do we want from them?
12. What do we want our child to know about this season of preparing?

Solo version: the same three questions and the conversation with the people who'll be part of your child's life. If family of origin is complicated, the change column is the most loving thing a parent can write; a therapist who works with family patterns is a good companion. **Discuss (30 XP).**

Connection Challenge (Training 6)

Couples who stayed together "turned toward" each other's small bids for connection far more often (Gottman & Driver, *Journal of Family Communication*). Ten minutes a day, seven days: one **check-in** (gratitude share → one word each from the emotion wheel → "listening or ideas?") and one **shared activity**.

Bond quiz (before Day 1 and after Day 7) — 1 = not at all · 5 = completely

THIS WEEK...	BEFORE	AFTER
I felt listened to		
I felt we were on the same team about the fertility journey		
We repaired quickly after tension		
I felt physically close to my partner		
I knew what my partner was feeling most days		
I noticed and responded to my partner's small bids		
I said something true I'd been holding		
We laughed together		
I felt hopeful about the family we're building		
I would choose this partner again today		
Total /50		

(Solo: replace "partner" with "my circle"; item 4 becomes "I reached out when I needed to.")

The week

DAY	CHECK-IN ✓	SHARED ACTIVITY	BID I TURNED TOWARD TODAY	DONE
1 · Listen	☐	10-min listening session (T1): "something about this journey I haven't said"		☐
2 · Walk	☐	20-min walk, hands held for part; "what are you looking forward to?"; no logistics for 10 min		☐
3 · Touch	☐	six-second hug at homecoming + 10 min warm touch (or eye gazing)		☐

DAY	CHECK-IN ✓	SHARED ACTIVITY	BID I TURNED TOWARD TODAY	DONE
4 · Cook	☐	fertility-plate dinner together; phones in the drawer; gratitude at the table		☐
5 · Repair	☐	one small unresolved thing through the conflict flowchart (T2)		☐
6 · Dream	☐	reread the future letter aloud; add one line to the legacy page		☐
7 · Rest & measure	☐	yoga together / nap / legs up the wall side by side; re-take the quiz		☐

Keep the check-in to ten minutes; same order every night. Its job is that nothing goes unseen for more than a day.

Reflection (30 XP)

Before _____ → After _____. The questions that moved most: _____

What a connected week actually felt like:

The night I least wanted to do the check-in, and what happened when I did:

What we'll keep from this week (Module 7 will build on it):

Share (20 XP): post what moved. Completing this training unlocks the Module 6 bonus (10 XP). Module 7 opens on Day 42.

Educational content only, not medical advice. Always consult your doctor or a qualified health professional before changing supplements, diet, exercise or detox practices, especially while trying to conceive.